



Opening a can

- **What?** Can opener
- **Who?** Robert Yeates
- **Where and when?** UK, 1855

Strange as it seems, it took more than 40 years from the invention of tin cans in 1810 for someone to come up with a usable can opener. Early cans were opened with a hammer and chisel, which could be dangerous. In 1855, a British cutlery company invented a simple handheld device with a single blade that was worked around the rim of the can to open it. The opener shown here is from the 1930s.

Magazine advertisement for the Toastmaster, 1951



Toasting bread

- **What?** Pop-up toaster
- **Who?** Charles Strite
- **Where and when?** US, 1919

The first electric toasters appeared in 1893, but weren't foolproof—they kept on toasting until someone turned them off, resulting in a lot of burned toast. The American inventor Charles Strite created a toaster that had a timer and springs to pop up the bread when it was ready. It was first used in the catering industry before a model for the home—the Toastmaster—was introduced in 1926. It's been a kitchen essential ever since.

Kitchen devices

In the not-too-distant past, most kitchen and cooking tasks, such as mixing, chopping, and toasting, had to be done by hand and were slow work. From the mid-19th century onward, inventors turned their attention toward creating devices that not only saved both time and effort with the preparation of food, but also helped with its storage.



Italian espresso machine, 2007

Faster coffee making

- **What?** Lever-operated espresso maker
- **Who?** Achille Gaggia
- **Where and when?** Italy, 1938

Ideas for speedy coffee brewing had been around since 1884, when Angelo Moriondo of Turin, Italy, was granted a patent for a steam-powered coffee maker. The large machine was not a success, and in 1903,

two other Italians, Luigi Bezzerra and Desiderio Pavoni, improved its design. Then, in 1938, the Italian engineer Achille Gaggia created the first steam coffee maker to be operated by lever. Smaller, but with much higher water pressure than earlier devices, it produced standard-sized cups of coffee similar to modern espresso.